he was ready to be hanged—saying he had followed Mahatma Gandhi's path. The court finally pronounced a life sentence. Out in Maisuma, the old slogans rang out as a small crowd of women and youth poured out their anger in well-rehearsed lines—like in a play in which everyone knew their part.

The 56-year-old was arrested in February 2019 as part of the crackdown against Kashmir's separatist leaders after the Pulwama suicide attack. Initially, he was slapped with the J&K Public Safety Act—which allows detention without trial for up to two years. But things took a decisive turn soon. In March, the JKLF was banned for five years. A month later, Yasin was shifted to NIA custody. A case opened in 2017 became the focus: he was charged under the stringent Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA). Booked alongside a dozen separatists, Yasin is the sole one to not contest the charges. The court appointed an amicus curiae for him as he refused to have a lawyer, but even after being counselled about the consequences, he pleaded guilty.

The news went international almost instantly—an unspoken factor, perhaps, in the quantum of sentence. Pakistan duly brought out its denunciations and demarches, and India offered the usual riposte. The British Parliament saw a debate. All the noise, exuding the same predictable air as the local protest, was not surprising. Yasin was one of the members of 'HAJY' group that launched the Kashmir insurgency back in 1989, a talismanic figure who had served as the local JKLF chief from April 1990 till his arrest on August 8 that tumultuous year. Freed in 1994, he announced a 'ceasefire', going against his associates and causing splits in the JKLF. While embracing pacifism—hence the reference to Gandhian methods—he stayed consistent on the cause as he rose to be part of the triumvirate that became the vanguard of the separatist movement, with the late Syed Ali Geelani and Mirwaiz Umar Farooq. With Geelani no more, Yasin in Tihar, and Mirwaiz under house arrest at his Nigeen residence, the space for a mainstream separatist leadership may vanish. Many feel this heralds a quiet end for the All Parties Hurriyat Conference, a conglomerate of over a dozen social and political organisations that came into being in 1993. The Hurriyat had given a political face to militancy and sought the resolution of the Kashmir dispute under UN resolutions or through tripartite talks—positing the people of Kashmir as a primary party alongside India and Pakistan. The Geelani-Yasin-Mirwaiz trio had had



**MANY FEEL THIS HERALDS A QUIET END FOR THE HURRIYAT, WHICH HAD GIVEN A POLITICAL FACE TO SEPARATISM**

perhaps their last hurrah as they set up the Joint Resistance Group in 2016, bringing unity to the angry streets after the killing of Hizbul Mujahideen commander Burhan Wani that year. In fact, that upsurge, a response to the strong anti-separatist policies of the Modi regime, had brought an even harder counter-response. Since 2017, almost all separatist leaders, from Shabir Shah to Masarat Alam, were jailed under terror-related charges, leaving the Hurriyat defunct. Even if Mirwaiz is occasionally allowed to move, it would be a challenge for him to mobilise the streets again in the face of New Delhi's iron-handed policies since August 2019.

Thus the muted scenes in Maisuma. Along the banks of the Jhelum and in the vicinity of Lal Chowk, Maisuma would often witness pitched street battles with security forces until Malik's arrest on February 22, 2019—earning it the sobriquet 'Gaza Strip'. But the working class residential neighbourhood, which also doubles up as a commercial auto hub, appears to show signs of protest fatigue. Nobody remembers the last protest before the verdict brought out a modest cohort. Almost everyone, including Yasin's comrades, tries to avoid the topic in conversations. "Nobody wants to languish in jail," says a Yasin associate, curtly. He has not visited the Maliks since August 2019, when he was picked up by police along with scores of politicians—including three former chief ministers—and activists from the pro-India as well as separatist camps. "Please do not write anything about me and do not tell anyone you met me," says the JKLF man. At the small house where only Yasin's mother and one sister stay now, the old influx of visitors has become rare. A relative recalls how people used to bring cooked food and tea for visitors when Yasin was jailed in the past. All that has stopped. "*Yeti chu waryaa khuouf te pressure. Naukri manz malaziman kadaan* (There's a lot of pressure and fear. People get sacked)," says the relative.

The People's Alliance for Gupkar Declaration, the five-party forum pushing for the restoration of J&K's status quo ante, only said the verdict would "compound uncertainties". PAGD spokesman and veteran CPI(M) leader M.Y. Tarigami said the BJP's "triumphalism" would prove "counterproductive". It may be left to Islamabad and London, where the JKLF was born in the early '70s, to issue the sterner protests. But New Delhi's real concern could lie elsewhere. Someone like Yasin had the courage to go against the popular narrative when militancy was at its peak—standing his ground against his own people back in 1994. With the peacenik in jail, the only space left may be for the gun. ■